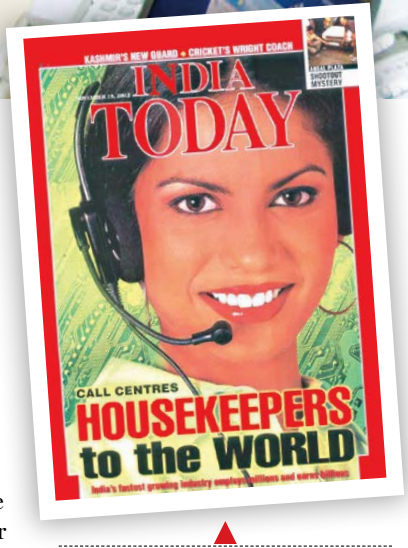
HINDUSTAN TIMES



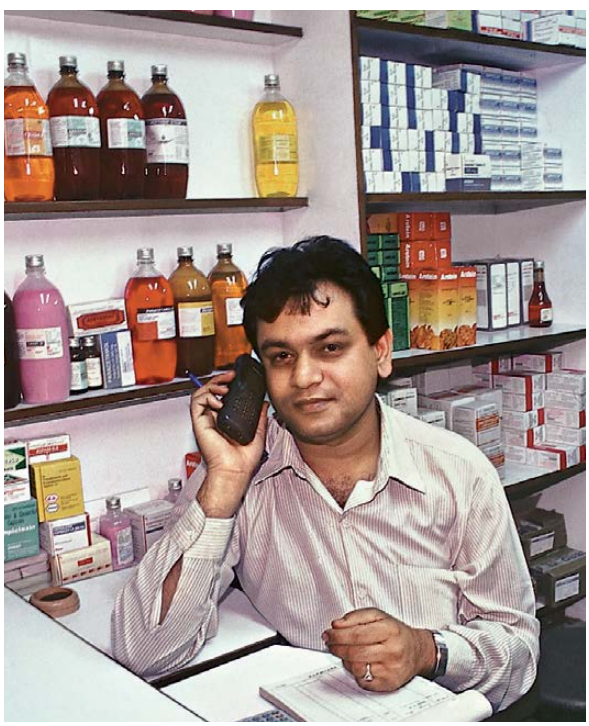
Nov. 18, 2002

introduced public internet access. Over the next decade, India had a new way to converse with itself. It was as if 16-lane highways of words had sprung up across the land, looping and bouncing back and forth, multiplying in sheer volumes of traffic. It was bound to become an economic acclerator of a sort not seen before.

Telecom was opened to private competition after decades of state monopoly, with groups like Tata and Essar partnering global majors such as AT&T and Hutchison, and Reliance charting a largely domestic path. Bharti Airtel soon emerged as a formidable player, while several early entrants struggled to sustain themselves as tariffs fell and capital requirements ballooned. The influx of capital and technology triggered fierce competition, rapid network expansion and a sharp rise in subscriber numbers.

Institutional architecture kept pace with market churn, as it had to. The Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI) was set up in 1997, to look at tariffs and ensure competition between operators was kept fair. The industry-government

LIGHTNING AGE Businesses, big and small, took to the cell phone and its ancillary technologies with vigour



SHARAD SAXENA